

Development Impact Plan

Statement

In reference to my supporting statements, I hope to pursue further studies in a Master of Economics to strengthen my capacity as an economist in Tonga. This study will equip me with analytical, technical, and professional skills that can drive change in Tonga. My reintegration will focus on applying these skills across these areas:

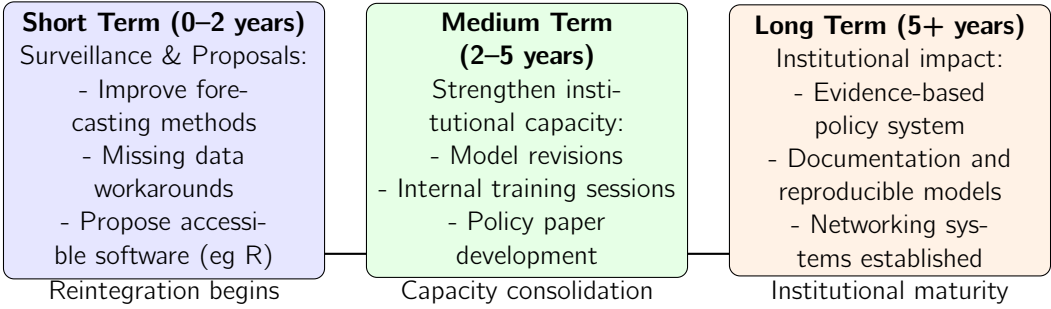
- **Technical Capacity** - I aim to deepen my skills in macroeconomic analysis and learn further quantitative methods that can improve the use of empirical analysis in policymaking and in decision-making processes. This will take the form of:
 - Applying new modelling techniques like nowcasting for publication lags or interpolation for incomplete data
 - Promoting the adoption of statistical software such as R, python, stata to complement excel-based systems
 - Encourage the investment in training staff to be able to update, modify, and adapt macroeconomic models based on our needs - which will of course pend on winning the support of top management.
- **Policy Quality** - While policy discussions in Tonga are often informed by economic intuition and experience, there is an opportunity to further support these with rigorous quantitative analysis and more independent data sources. Data that is reliably sourced or mathematically rigorous in calculating are hard to refute in policy discussion. Practically, improvements could include:
 - Building the capacity to collect primary data and support policy analysis with quantified regression results
 - Building adeptness for creating proxy variables to model effects that are hard to directly observe
- **Institutional quality and reforms** -A key focus of my reintegration will be to ensure that the skills I gain are embedded within the institution rather than remaining at an individual level. To achieve this, I intend to
 - initiate practical knowledge-sharing activities within my division, such as small group training sessions, walkthroughs of modelling techniques
 - developing simple documentation practises for key frameworks so that these skills and methods are reproducible.
- **Networking and connections** -During this proposed study, I expect to build connections with academics, peers, and professionals working in similar policy environments. These will prove to be valuable networks upon returning, which i will engage to access relevant policy insights, methodologies, and tools that can be adapted to Tonga's context. Practically, this may involve sharing resources, maintaining communication with academic mentors, and introducing new approaches through internal presentations or discussions within the Ministry. Where possible, I will also explore opportunities for collaboration or knowledge exchange that can support ongoing capacity building beyond my immediate role.

In relation to these outcomes, i see this study as an opportunity that will also strengthen my personal development through improved professional confidence, communication, leadership skills in team settings, and the ability to navigate conflict.

Constraints

There are several constraints that may obstruct these efforts, which are largely structural and at times, institutional. One of these is the limited availability of data in Tonga. Economic data is often at a low frequency (annual), incomplete, or published with long lags (eg actual statistics for GDP is dated 2 years back). Theres no telling to what extent further studies can help me workaroud these structural limitations but as mentioned above, some methodologies (like nowcasting or interpolation methods) make me optimistic about what postgraduate studies can offer. Other challenges may include a low institutional appetite for change and adopting new methodologies, particularly where existing processes are well-established. The aim is then efforts towards a gradual long-term institutional reform.

Timeline



The elements of the development impact plan can be summarised by the timeline figure above, where within the first 2 years upon returning i find the immediate changes that can be implemented is introducing the proposed changes - such as indicating better forecasting methods or workarounds for incomplete data and new software. In the medium term, I believe there is room for strengthening institutional capacity, where our current models can be reviewed or modified and the engagement of staff in trainings to be able to modify these models is mobilized. Finally, in the long term, the firm footing of these training sessions, these evidence-based policy papers, and overall improved technical capacity will lead to improved policy systems, and better documentation and reproducibility.

Conclusion

In summary, this document set out to outline the development impacts that could potentially realize form this scholarship study - which ranged across developing my own technical and professional ability to contributing to institutional reform. I acknowledge that these goals are ambitious and will require time, resources, collabrations and alignment with Ministry priorities, however, these goals provide a clear direction and reflect my commitment to applying these skills upon return. These goals of course are flexible to change with what is practical.